

Chapter 114_2 - Discord

At the same time, all the immortal sects erupted in discussion. Several bold disciples shouted loudly: "Wasn't it supposed to be a demon creature? This magical artifact didn't catch any demons at all!"

The people from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate breathed a great sigh of relief and stood up one after another. Seeing that the disturbance was difficult to control, Elder Pingyao's voice echoed throughout: "Wen Yaojun once led people to break into our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, claiming repeatedly that there was a world-destroying person in our sect, saying that they possessed demon roots and were certainly a disaster. Taking advantage of the sect master and elders eliminating demons, this caused great chaos in our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate - disciples were captured and many were severely injured."

"Yet now you cannot find these demon roots. How does Penglai explain this?" Her steady voice was deafening, causing everyone to cover their ears.

"Today this demon race must have used some unorthodox methods to escape this tribulation. This person is sinister and cunning, truly untrustworthy!" Wen Yaojun was somewhat panicked at this time, his voice no longer as confident as before. "Besides, the prophecy is real - she cannot escape no matter what!"

Then he shouted sternly: "First bind this demon creature and take her back to Penglai. The Emperor will make his own judgment!"

However, just as his words fell, an immortal soldier came from behind, his face flushed red as he whispered something in his ear. Wen Yaojun's eyes widened and his hair stood on end in rage.

Supported by the immortal soldier, he finally stood steady and roared: "You demon creature, you actually ordered people to surround Danding Manor¹. What audacity!"

Ning Fuyi curved her lips slightly, reached out to pull over a chair and sat down, accepting a cup of water that Du Baishuang handed her, as if everything happening had nothing to do with her.

"What? You Penglai are allowed to catch turtles in a jar², but I'm not allowed to escape like a golden cicada shedding its shell³? Don't be too thick-skinned." Ning Fuyi blew on the floating tea leaves.

"Your face shouldn't be too thick."

"That day I was merely an ordinary disciple, yet you Penglai used a baseless prophecy to condemn me. So many experts besieged me, a junior whose cultivation had only reached Clear Realm, causing me severe injuries and endless suffering, then imprisoned me in Canghai Tower⁴ to endure countless torments! You Penglai claim to be immortals, yet do nothing but shameful deeds. Even when capturing me, you only know how to take advantage of others' misfortune. So hypocritical, yet you still dream of becoming the leader of all immortal sects?"

Though her words were not harsh, each sentence was contemptuous. The more casually she spoke, the more people's hearts trembled.

Because that day was too chaotic and few people were present, most of the immortal sect members didn't know the full story. They only heard flying rumors and assumed Ning Fuyi had killed Mei Chengsi and was a world-destroying person. Now hearing her speak this way, complex feelings immediately arose in their hearts.

"You must not..."

"What? The great Penglai doesn't even have the patience to hear me say a few more words? Such lack of tolerance?"

Ning Fuyi raised her voice to interrupt Wen Yaojun's words. Each sentence was a question, yet each sentence was not really a question.

"Today I ask not only you, but also the immortal sects present: what heinous crimes have I, Ning Fuyi, committed to deserve such treatment from all of you?"

"I killed Mei Chengsi because he wanted to kill me repeatedly for the sake of the sect master position, and even severely injured my senior brother who protected me, nearly killing him. I killed him not out of bullying, but for self-preservation!"

"Besides this, when have I ever done anything to wrong the six realms or the common people? Just because of a baseless prophecy, am I born guilty? If you say I'm evil then I'm evil - who condemns me, and who has the right to condemn me!"

Her black robes were so dark they merged with the night, while her face was exposed in the light and shadow. Her words left everyone below speechless, with no one making another sound.

"You immortal sects have been arrogant for too long. You always talk about the common people under heaven, sounding full of righteousness, yet you turn a blind eye to the grass beneath your feet. Cultivating immortality ultimately becomes about fighting for power and profit, protecting oneself wisely. I ask, how many people truly deserve the word 'immortal'?"

She seized the opportunity to curse out all the words from these two lifetimes, almost including everyone standing in the elegant pavilions. Yet those cultivators who were all outstanding figures in the martial world remained completely silent, with not one person refuting her.

Wen Yaojun's hands were nearly crushed by his own grip. He took this opportunity to secretly send out a signal, ordering others to capture Ning Fuyi, so Hei Lin⁵ and others hidden in the dark silently departed.

At the same time, in the elegant pavilion where the Jiang family was located across the way, Jiang Li had been staring intently at the area behind Wen Yaojun. Seeing that patch of black robe corner disappear, she immediately turned around, only to be called back by Jiang Wuying.

"Jiang Li! Are you going to disobey this old woman again!" Jiang Wuying shouted angrily.

Jiang Li's body stopped, but she didn't turn around.

"Grandmother, I've always listened to you in everything, which is why I already missed once."

"I don't want to listen anymore."

Having said this, she no longer cared about Jiang Wuying's heavy breathing, strode out of the elegant pavilion, her body transforming into orange-yellow flowing light, shuttling through the narrow corridors, accurately intercepting a mass of black energy at Ning Fuyi's door.

Both spun around and landed. Hei Lin expressionlessly drew out an ancient silver dagger, her eyes with thick lashes sweeping over the woman's face as she spoke: "If you don't want to die, step aside."

Jiang Li removed her cloak with both hands, holding it in front of her like a long whip, her beautiful eyes glancing around: "What if today I refuse to step aside?"

...

Ning Fuyi was unaware of what was happening behind her. She still stood in place, unhurriedly removing a prayer bead from her sleeve and spinning it between her fingertips.

"Actually, my coming here today is not to waste words, but to let you all see what the real Penglai truly is."

As she spoke, she threw out the prayer bead. The originally fingertip-sized bead suddenly swelled to the size of a full moon, and countless pieces of paper flew out from the prayer bead like celestial maidens scattering flowers into the crowd. From afar, it looked like flying snow in March, graceful and moving.

The disciples reached out to catch the papers, whispering among themselves. The papers were all written with names - some familiar, most unknown.

"Do you all know of Penglai's secret technique, the Memory Weaving Spectrum⁶? It can reshape people's memories - not puppets, but better than puppets. These are the names of cultivators who, over the past two thousand years, appeared to have gone into seclusion but were actually memory-reshaped by Penglai and claimed as their own. Perhaps your relatives and friends are also on this list."

As soon as these words were spoken, it was like a stone stirring up a thousand waves. The venue buzzed with deafening noise, and several sect masters were also greatly shocked, grabbing papers and looking at each other in dismay.

"Nonsense! My Penglai was born with divine mandate - how could we commit such petty acts! Everyone, the world-destroyer is right before your eyes, why don't you act!" Wen Yaojun shouted sternly at the immortal sects.

But at this moment, all the lights in the hall went out again. In the pitch darkness, layers of fierce wind arose, blowing people askew. The woman's laughter echoed in their ears, disturbing their ears painfully, causing everyone to bend over and take cover.

Chu Qingqiu was also blown by the wind until she couldn't open her eyes, but she quickly applied two pieces of immortal power to her eyes. Then she saw across the fierce wind that the woman embraced Du Baishuang around the waist with gentle movements, gracefully rushing out of the barrier and disappearing into the myriad points of starlight overhead.

Until her final departure, she never looked at her again.

Chu Qingqiu felt her whole body go weak. She slowly hugged her knees and crouched down. When she was Su Mo⁷, she had promised they would definitely meet again.

Could it be because she had only promised Su Mo?

The wind was still blowing, and outside was in complete chaos. But for the first time, Chu Qingqiu didn't want to care about anything. She just quietly crouched in the corner, waiting for the fierce wind to stop.

After an unknown amount of time, the wind finally began to subside. She silently raised her eyes, only to discover a piece of differently colored paper had fallen by her feet.

She reached out to pick it up, seeing dragon and phoenix calligraphy dancing across it, with a qilin⁸ beast claw print at the end.

It read: "Ye City, Golden Bridge."

Since the Demon Elimination Conference, many days had passed. No matter how much of a farce it was, it had to come to an end. The crowded masses on Liugen Huayan Island⁹ gradually dispersed, and the island returned to its original appearance.

Lively, yet hiding secrets everywhere.

Ning Fuyi's strategy of sowing discord had indeed worked well. Although Penglai strongly denied those secret techniques, once seeds of doubt were planted, they easily took root and sprouted. As long as the six sects no longer completely trusted Penglai's commands, that was victory for her.

This day in Ye City, peach blossoms were brilliant and willows were beautiful. The distant mountains looked as if washed by water, undulating under the clear, warm sky.

"Master, why don't you return to Purple Cloud Peak¹⁰? What are you doing in this mortal realm?" Qiu Yi, whose body had become much thinner, followed Chu Qingqiu with small steps, speaking to her face covered by a veil.

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak for a long while, finally saying: "I heard that Ye City has the most beautiful peach blossoms. This master wants to take a look."

"When did Master start loving to look at peach blossoms..." Qiu Yi said quietly.

"How is your body?" Chu Qingqiu changed the subject and inquired.

Although Qiu Yi had been saved by her using flower petals, she ultimately had lingering health problems. Her body was no longer as strong as before. Perhaps because she had died once, her originally flamboyant personality had also become much more restrained, often quiet as if she had become a different person.

"Master need not worry. This disciple is very healthy." Qiu Yi touched her head and said. Her gaze wandered for a while before she spoke: "Master came here for Ning Fuyi, didn't you?"

Chu Qingqiu's eyelashes hidden under the veil trembled, but she said nothing.

"Actually, I remember everything that happened in the mortal realm..."

"Qiu Yi!" Chu Qingqiu suddenly stopped and turned around, causing Qiu Yi to immediately tense up and not dare to breathe.

"Didn't I say that matters of the mortal realm are not to be mentioned again?" Chu Qingqiu said coldly.

Qiu Yi's hands twisted behind her back as she nodded carefully. She knew that ever since her resurrection, Chu Qingqiu was normal in everything except she wouldn't allow her to mention even half a word about mortal realm matters, as if she wanted to completely forget that she had once been Su Mo.

She would become furious whenever it was mentioned. For a time, Qiu Yi couldn't tell whether her master becoming moody was a good thing or a bad thing.

"Then about what you asked this disciple to inquire about regarding Chuwei Hall¹¹ - should this disciple still speak?" Qiu Yi said quietly.

Chu Qingqiu stepped forward, her voice light: "Speak."

Qiu Yi had become a bird, so now she could understand bird conversations, making her extremely suitable for gathering information.

"I heard several magpies say that Chuwei Hall stands just outside Ye City, but uses a barrier to hide its appearance, so ordinary people cannot discover it. They, they said..."

"They said that since the Chuwei Hall master returned to her sect, she has never left, indulging daily in sensual pleasures and wine, recruiting many beautiful little demons inside."

Qiu Yi's face reddened somewhat as she said this. She touched her cheek before continuing: "Those magpies heard that Ning Fuyi even built a dual... quiet cultivation place for this purpose. Whenever people pass by, they dare not linger long after hearing the sounds."

As soon as her words fell, there was a cracking sound - Chu Qingqiu had somehow crushed some object.

Chu Qingqiu felt layers of suppressed fire burning her heart and lungs, her mind momentarily blank. When she came to her senses, she had bitten her lips until they bled.

One Du Baishuang would have been enough, but now...

"What kind of behavior is this! She, why has she become like this!" Chu Qingqiu was so angry her words carried a sobbing tone.

Qiu Yi had never seen Chu Qingqiu this furious before - anger mixed with grievance, making that figure appear even more fragile.

Qiu Yi quickly tried to comfort her, but suddenly met Chu Qingqiu's red eyes after she turned around.

"Qiu Yi, take this venerable to Chuwei Hall!" she said in a low voice.

Footnotes

¹ **Danding Manor (丹鼎府)** - A mansion or estate associated with alchemy and cultivation, where the current scene is taking place.

² **Catch turtles in a jar (瓮中捉鳖)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to catch something easily when it's trapped with no escape route.

³ **Golden cicada shedding its shell (金蝉脱壳)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to escape by using a decoy or misdirection, leaving enemies to attack an empty shell.

⁴ **Canghai Tower (沧海塔)** - Literally "Vast Sea Tower," a prison or detention facility used by Penglai.

⁵ **Hei Lin (黑鳞)** - Literally "Black Scales," one of Ning Fuyi's subordinates.

⁶ **Memory Weaving Spectrum (抽丝幻谱)** - A secret technique that can manipulate and reshape memories.

⁷ **Su Mo (苏陌)** - Chu Qingqiu's identity when she lived as a mortal in her previous life.

⁸ **Qilin (麒麟)** - A mythical Chinese creature, often called a Chinese unicorn, symbolizing prosperity and serenity.

⁹ **Liugen Huayan Island (六根华严岛)** - The island where the Demon Elimination Conference took place.

¹⁰ **Purple Cloud Peak (紫霞峰)** - Chu Qingqiu's mountain residence and cultivation location.

¹¹ **Chuwei Hall (憺畏堂)** - Ning Fuyi's organization and residence.